Life Course Theory, Sen's Capability Approach & Keyes's Social Well-Being

VE5915701 — Community Well-being and Digital Learning Innovation | Module I ・ Week 3

LEARNING GUIDELINE 課堂學習指引

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Today's Session at a Glance 本次課程概覽

Goal 目標

Propose a research statement integrating Life Course Theory, Sen's Capability Approach, and Keyes's Social Well-Being across a specific target population and digital learning context.

Core Readings

DeHaan, Hirai & Ryan (2016) — Nussbaum's Capabilities + SDT Basic Needs

Keyes (1998) — Social Well-Being

Key Concepts

Functionings vs. Capabilities · Conversion Factors · Five SWB Dimensions · Digital Inclusion · SDG Alignment

Output 產出

Draft Research Statement (end of session) — feeds into W4 Individual Research Proposal (10%)

The Three Frameworks

Life Course Theory
Temporal and structural scaffolding across development

Sen's Capability Approach
Converting resources into real freedoms

Social Well-Being
Measuring societal outcomes and integration

These three frameworks are not parallel alternatives — they operate at different levels of analysis and connect sequentially, from developmental context through transformative mechanism to measurable social outcome.

1A • LIFE COURSE THEORY 生命歷程理論

Life Course Theory

Core Premise: Human development is shaped by the intersection of historical time, social location, and individual agency across the entire lifespan — not just childhood or a single stage.

Five Key Principles 五大核心原則

1	**Linked Lives 連結生命** Social relationships across generations shape individual trajectories.
2	**Historical Time & Place 歷史時地** The same event (e.g., pandemic, digital disruption) has different effects depending on when and where it occurs in a life.
3	**Timing of Lives 生命時序** The impact of transitions depends on their timing — early vs. late life digital exclusion carries different consequences.
4	**Human Agency 人的能動性** Individuals construct their own life course through choices within social constraints.
5	**Lifelong Development 終身發展** Development is continuous — capabilities can be built or lost at any stage.

Application to Digital Learning

→ Crisis as Turning Point

Pandemic / digital exclusion constitutes a 'turning point' — altering trajectories of capability development.

→ Linked Lives Online

Intergenerational digital co-learning (老幼共學) as a mechanism of linked-lives mutual benefit.

→ Historical Cohort Effects

Different generations experience the same digital platform differently — SST (Carstensen) explains why older adults maintain smaller but more meaningful online networks.

→ Agency ↔ Capability

Life course agency operationalizes as Sen's 'effective freedom to achieve functionings.'

Sen's Capability Approach

Core Argument: Well-being should be evaluated not by utility, income, or resources — but by what people are actually able to do and be. Development is the expansion of real freedoms (capabilities).

Functionings, Capabilities & Conversion Factors

Functionings
功能性活動（已實現）

What a person *actually does or is* — e.g., participating in an online community, completing a digital learning task, exercising social voice.

Capabilities
能力（可實現的自由）

The real opportunities available — the set of functionings a person can choose from. Digital inclusion = capability to participate in online civic life.

Conversion Factors
轉換因子

Resources (like internet access) must be converted into capabilities. Three types: Personal (skills, disability) • Social (norms, family support) • Environmental (infrastructure, policy)

1B • DEHAAN, HIRAI & RYAN (2016)

Bridging Sen + SDT 兩個框架的橋接研究

Key Finding: Capabilities (measured by Nussbaum's Central Human Capabilities) predict subjective well-being — substantially mediated by SDT's three Basic Psychological Needs (Autonomy, Competence, Relatedness).

Path Coefficient

Capabilities → Need Satisfaction β = .85 (US), .81 (India)

Mediation

SDT needs explain 60.9–72.2% of the Capability → SWB effect

Cross-Cultural

Pattern holds across individualist (US) and collectivist (India) samples

Course Framework Connection

Autonomy Need = Capability to self-direct digital learning pathways

Competence Need = Capability to achieve digital functionings (CLO 1, 3)

Relatedness Need = Capability for social participation (→ Keyes Social Integration)

Research Gap: This mediation pathway is untested in digital crisis disruption contexts → your W4 opportunity

Keyes's Social Well-Being

Core Argument: Individual psychological well-being is insufficient — human flourishing requires positive functioning within one's social world. Keyes identifies five distinct, independently measurable dimensions of social well-being.

> "To flourish is to love and do great work, to love others and to be loved, and to matter to the world." — Keyes (2007)

Five Dimensions of Social Well-Being

Social Integration 社會融合

The sense of belonging to a community and sharing important qualities with others. *Course link: Digital Mobilization → Synchronous Social Presence; Intergenerational co-learning*

Social Acceptance 社會接納

Positive attitudes toward others and acceptance of human nature — trusting that people are capable and kind. *Course link: AI companions reducing loneliness; digital safe harbors*

Social Contribution 社會貢獻

The belief that one's daily activities are valued by and useful to society. *Course link: Resource crowdsourcing; peer teaching; community fieldwork (Assessment III)*

Social Actualization 社會實現

The belief that society has potential for growth that can benefit people like oneself. *Course link: Capacity Rebuilding (DV); Final Proposal outcome measure*

Social Coherence 社會一致性

The perception that social life has a discernible logic, predictability, and meaning. *Course link: UDL, trauma-informed pedagogy; cognitive clarity through structured learning*

1C • CRITICAL DISTINCTION

Social vs. Psychological vs. Emotional Well-Being

Social WB (Keyes)

How one relates to and functions within the social world — public, outward. Five dimensions measured by 33-item, 7-point Likert scale.

Psychological WB (Ryff, 1989)

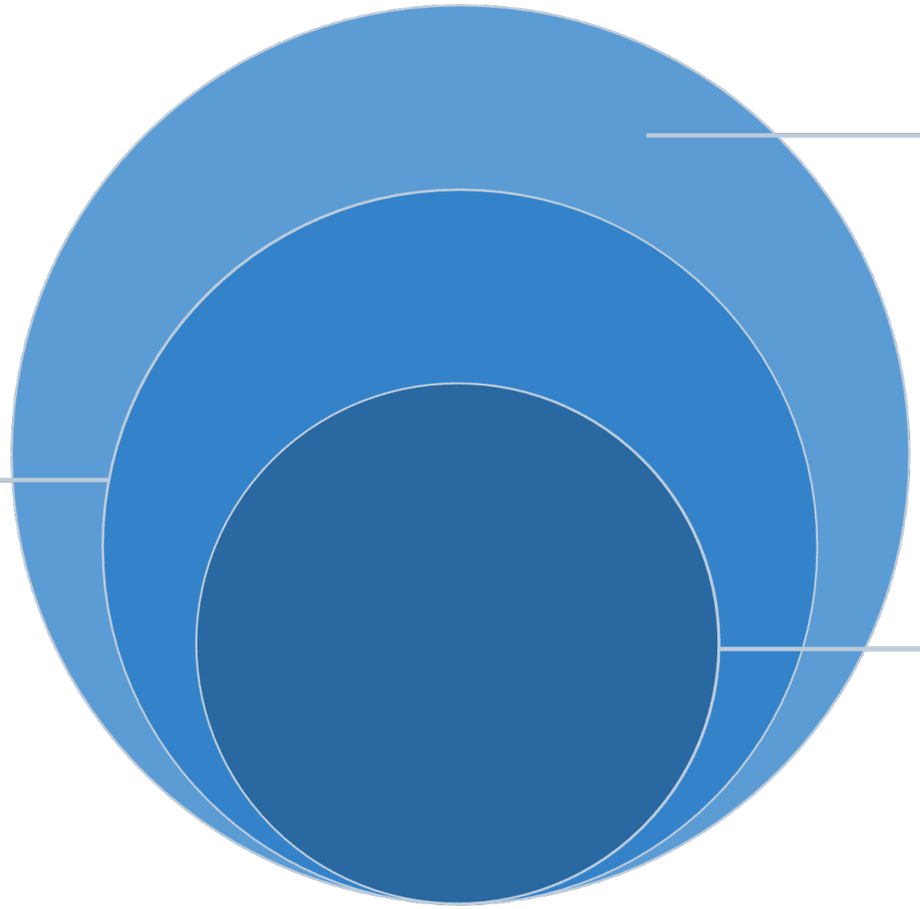
Personal growth, purpose, self-acceptance — private, inward. Distinct from social functioning.

Emotional WB (Diener)

Subjective happiness and life satisfaction — hedonic. Focuses on affect and life evaluation.

Measurement Note: In your study, SWB is used as the pre-test outcome variable (T1/T2/T3). Social Actualization often shows a floor effect at T1 in crisis conditions — expect the largest gain by T3. Keyes items require re-anchoring to 'online community' or 'digital learning community' context.

How the Three Frameworks Connect



Keyes's Social Well-Being

Outcome measurement: five dimensions, aligns with SDG 3/4/10

Sen's Capability Approach

Resources to real freedom: conversion factors, functionings, SDT bridge

Life Course Theory

Temporal & structural context: turning points, linked lives, agency

Life Course Theory contextualizes the developmental trajectory → Capability Approach identifies the transformative mechanism → Keyes's SWB measures the social outcome.

PART 2 • INTEGRATION DETAIL

Three Levels of Analysis

1

Life Course Theory

Level: Temporal & Structural

HOW developmental trajectories unfold across time, generations, and social positions — the longitudinal scaffolding.

- Turning points = crises (W2 IV)
- Linked lives = social support (Mediator)
- Agency = capability expansion

2

Sen's Capability Approach

Level: Resources → Real Freedom

WHAT needs to be transformed — converting digital resources into actual capabilities via conversion factors.

- Conversion factors = Moderator
- Functionings = measurable outcomes
- SDT bridge (DeHaan et al., 2016)

3

Keyes's Social Well-Being

Level: Outcome Measurement

HOW WELL the capability expansion worked — measuring social-relational consequences across five dimensions.

- 5 dimensions = primary DV (T1/T2/T3)
- Actualization = apex outcome
- SDG 3/4/10 alignment

PART 3 · DIGITAL INCLUSION 數位融合

Digital Inclusion as a Capability

Having internet access is not the same as having the capability to participate digitally. Conversion factors determine whether access becomes functioning.

Three-Level Digital Divide (Ragnedda, 2017)

1

Level 1 — Access
Physical infrastructure

2

Level 2 — Skills
Digital literacy and confidence

3

Level 3 — Benefits
Tangible outcomes in health, employment, and civic life

Helsper's Corresponding Fields Model (2012): Social disadvantage in economic, cultural, social, and personal fields maps directly onto digital disadvantage — and vice versa. UDL 3.0 (CAST, 2024) functions as a structural conversion factor, removing environmental barriers to capability formation.

SDG Alignment Matrix

SDG	Goal	Connection
SDG 3	Good Health & Well-Being	Keyes's 5 SWB dimensions as health outcome; digital tools reducing isolation
SDG 4	Quality Education	Digital learning capability as equitable educational access; UDL as structural conversion factor
SDG 10	Reduced Inequalities	Capability approach addresses conversion factor gaps; three-level digital divide remediation
SDG 11	Sustainable Communities	Community flourishing as social capital; intergenerational digital co-learning
SDG 17	Partnerships	Community informatics; crowdsourced digital resource mobilization

PART 4 ・ WORKSHOP 研究陳述起草

Drafting Your Research Statement

🎯 Goal: Write a 6-7 sentence research statement that integrates all three theoretical frameworks into one empirically testable claim aimed at equity and SDG achievement.

PART 4 • TEMPLATE

Research Statement Template
研究陳述目標句範本

> "A specific target population utilizes conversion factors to overcome crises, transforming digital resources into capabilities to realize social participation functionings, which ultimately enhances community well-being and achieves social equity and the SDGs."

Target Population

Life Course: Cohort / Age / Social Location

Conversion Factors

Sen: Personal • Social • Environmental

Digital Resources → Capabilities

Sen + Digital Inclusion: 3-Level Divide

Community Well-Being / SDGs

Keyes: 5 Dimensions + SDG 3/4/10

Guiding Steps

01

Identify Your Target Population

Choose a specific group whose digital inclusion relates to a life course stage or transition. Apply Life Course lens: What is the cohort effect? What turning point do they face? How do linked lives shape their digital access?

02

Map the Conversion Factors

Identify specific barriers: Personal (literacy, disability, language), Social (family norms, peer support, policy), Environmental (infrastructure, platform design). Which is most critical and addressable?

03

Define the Digital Capability

What specific functioning do you want them to achieve? Be concrete. Map this functioning to one of Keyes's five dimensions.

04

Draft Your Research Statement

Using the template, write 2–3 sentences covering: (a) population + life course context, (b) conversion factor barrier and intervention, (c) digital capability, (d) Keyes dimension as outcome, (e) one SDG connection.

05

Peer Sharing & Critique (W4/W5)

Share with a partner. Check: Is the population specific? Is the conversion factor linked to the intervention? Is the capability vs. functioning distinction maintained? Is the Keyes dimension appropriate?

Three Exemplar Research Statements

These examples illustrate how the five template components work together. Each targets a different population, conversion factor, and Keyes dimension.

Example 1

Older Adults (75+) with Low Digital Literacy in Rural Communities

Example 2

Migrant Workers with Language Barriers in Digital Training Programs

Example 3

Graduate Students Experiencing Post-Pandemic Technostress

EXAMPLE 1

Older Adults (75+) — Rural Digital Literacy

> Rural older adults aged 75+ face third-level digital divide barriers (environmental: infrastructure gaps; personal: low digital confidence) that prevent them from converting internet access into capabilities for social participation. By providing structured intergenerational digital literacy co-learning programs (social conversion factor) aligned with Socioemotional Selectivity Theory, this population can develop the functioning of sustained online social connection, thereby enhancing Social Integration and Social Actualization (Keyes, 1998) and contributing to SDG 3 and SDG 11.

Life Course

SST (Carstensen) — selective, meaningful connections in late life; cohort effect of pre-digital socialization

Capability

Social participation online; conversion factor = structured co-learning (social)

Keyes + SDGs

Social Integration (primary) + Social Actualization (secondary) | SDG 3, 11

EXAMPLE 2

Migrant Workers — Language Barriers in Digital Training

> Migrant workers with limited host-country language proficiency face intersecting personal (language) and social (institutional exclusion) conversion factor barriers that transform digital training platforms into exclusion mechanisms. Applying UDL 3.0 principles as an environmental conversion factor — specifically multilingual interfaces and visual learning paths — enables this population to develop occupational digital self-efficacy, enhancing Social Contribution and Social Coherence (Keyes, 1998) while advancing SDG 4 and SDG 10.

Life Course

Timing — migration as life course turning point; linked lives disrupted by geographic displacement

Capability

Occupational digital self-efficacy; conversion factor = UDL multilingual design (environmental)

Keyes + SDGs

Social Contribution + Social Coherence | SDG 4, 10

EXAMPLE 3

Graduate Students — Post-Pandemic Technostress

> Graduate students navigating post-pandemic digital learning environments exhibit elevated technostress — a crisis disruption that diminishes the personal conversion factor of digital self-regulation and erodes SDT-based relatedness need satisfaction online. Through a Resilient Pedagogy intervention (trauma-informed + UDL-aligned) as a social-environmental conversion factor, students can rebuild the capability for meaningful digital scholarly participation, enhancing Social Coherence and Social Actualization (Keyes, 1998) — measurable at T1 (usually pre-test), T2, and T3 — in alignment with SDG 4.

Life Course

Turning point = pandemic; historical time effect on emerging adult development; linked lives = peer support networks

Capability

Meaningful digital scholarly participation; conversion factors = Resilient Pedagogy (social + environmental)

Keyes + SDGs

Social Coherence (primary) + Social Actualization (secondary) | SDG 4

READINGS • QUICK REFERENCE

Today's Readings 本次閱讀速查表

Reading 1: DeHaan, Hirai & Ryan (2016)

Nussbaum's Capabilities and SDT's Basic Psychological Needs — Journal of Happiness Studies, 17(5)
Focus on: How 10 Central Human Capabilities map onto SDT's three needs; why the mediation model matters; how β coefficients differ between US and India; where this study fits in the Capability → Conversion Factor → Functioning → Keyes SWB chain.

Key terms: Central Human Capabilities • Path coefficient (β = .85) • Mediation • Cross-cultural validation

Reading 2: Keyes (1998)

Social Well-Being — Social Psychology Quarterly, 61(2), 121–140

Focus on: How Keyes distinguishes Social WB from Psychological and Emotional WB; the core question each dimension asks; which dimensions are most affected by digital learning participation.

Memory anchor:

- Integration — 'Do I belong?'
- Acceptance — 'Do I trust others?'
- Contribution — 'Do I matter?'
- Actualization — 'Is the world getting better for people like me?'
- Coherence — 'Does social life make sense?'

Take-Away Summary 本次學習重點

Life Course

Situates the population in time, generation, and turning points — the developmental *why*

Capability Approach

Identifies what needs converting — access → functioning — and the three-type barrier

Keyes SWB

Measures the social outcome — which of five dimensions improved, and by how much

Research Goal

Connects all three into one empirically testable statement aimed at equity + SDG achievement

→ Your W4/W5 Individual Research Proposal (10%) begins with today's drafted statement. VE5915701 — Community Well-being and Digital Learning Innovation | Module I, Week 3